against such landholders'?

'Landholder', 'landlord' – zamindar – is what the Mughal administration called the kings of Rajasthan, amongst whom the ranas of Mewar had long held semi-mythical status. Like Akbar and the Niru'un descendants of Alanqoa, many Rajput dynasties claimed descent from light – the greatest light of all, in fact, that of the sun. The colonial administrator, adventurer and aficionado of Rajput lore Colonel James Tod uses this fact, among others, to trace a Central Asian lineage for the Rajputs, even proposing an etymological link between 'Sakadwipa', 'Scythia' and 'Chagatai'. The Rajput could hardly be more different, Tod continues, from 'the meek Hindu . . . worshippers of kine'. It is 'his horse, his sword, and the sun' the Rajput worships, 'and attends more to the martial song of the bard than to the litany of the Brahman'.[10]

Tod has been described as 'notoriously a partisan of the Rajput princes',[11] an accusation that would, one day, be hurled at Akbar, too. Whether or not they shared Central Asian ancestry, the Mughal warlords and the Rajputs did share a 'warrior ethos'.[12] Thus, Bihari Mal's poise in the face of Akbar's excited elephant had impressed the boy at first sight. Many years into his reign, Akbar would talk of how he had grown his hair 'from sympathy with the natives of India'[13] and also, perhaps, in imitation of their martial ways.

Among these Rajput warriors, the ranas of Mewar claimed first place, and Chittorgarh was their pre-eminent bastion. This magnificent fortress, towering over the surrounding plains, had not always belonged to Mewar – it was conquered[14] in the eighth century by a Mewar king of legendary fame, Bappa Rawal. In 1303, some half a millennium after Bappa's rule – and his retirement, some say, to Khorasan[15] – Chittorgarh fell out of its rana's hands, to Alauddin Khilji. Two centuries later, the fort fell again, this time to the sultan of Gujarat – but also, in a sense, to dissensions within the Mewar dynasty.

Rana Bikramjit, who held Mewar's throne before and after the sultan of Gujarat's brief occupation, was not a popular king, being 'insolent, passionate, and vindictive, and utterly regardless of that respect which his proud nobles rigidly exacted'.[16] So detested was he – and so bereft of the qualities of his father, Rana Sanga – that his chiefs conspired to kill him,